

Lecture 3: Mail Merge, Printing & PDF Export

Mail Merge & Automated Letter Writing · Printing Documents · Exporting to PDF

Learning Outcomes

- Explain what mail merge is, and identify its two essential components.
- Describe, step by step, the process of performing a mail merge to create personalised letters.
- Explain what a data source and a merge field are, with examples.
- Name the different types of output a mail merge can produce.
- Describe the key options available when printing a document, including page range, duplex, and orientation.
- Explain what a PDF is, why it is used, and how to export a Word document to PDF.
- Differentiate between printing a document and exporting it to PDF.
- Answer short, medium, and long-answer (up to 15 marks) examination questions on this topic with full explanations and examples.

1 Recap — From Formatting Tools to Automation & Output

Lecture 2 studied how to build and format a single document using tables, columns, lists, objects, and page layout tools. This lecture studies two very different, equally practical skills: mail merge, which automates writing the SAME letter for MANY different people at once, and the final step every document eventually needs — printing it, or exporting it to PDF for sharing and archiving.

Important Point for Exams

As with Lecture 2, this topic is practical and procedural. Examiners commonly ask you to describe the exact steps of a process (“explain how to perform a mail merge”) or to differentiate between two related actions (“differentiate between printing and exporting to PDF”). Learn both the concept and the exact ribbon tab or menu path for each feature.

2 What Is Mail Merge?

Mail merge is a feature that combines a single template document with a list of data to automatically generate multiple personalised versions of that document — one for every entry in the list — without the user needing to retype or manually edit each copy.

Component	What It Is	Example
Main Document	The template letter, containing fixed text plus placeholders for the details that will change	“Dear «FirstName», your balance of «AmountDue» is due on «DueDate».”
Data Source	A list of records supplying the changing details for each recipient	An Excel spreadsheet with columns FirstName, AmountDue, DueDate

Real-Life Example

A college wants to send the same reminder letter to 500 students who have unpaid fees, but each letter must show that specific student's name and exact amount due. Retyping 500 letters by hand would take days; mail merge produces all 500 personalised letters in seconds from one template and one spreadsheet.

3 The Mail Merge Process — Step by Step

Mail merge is performed entirely from the Mailings tab, following five steps in order.

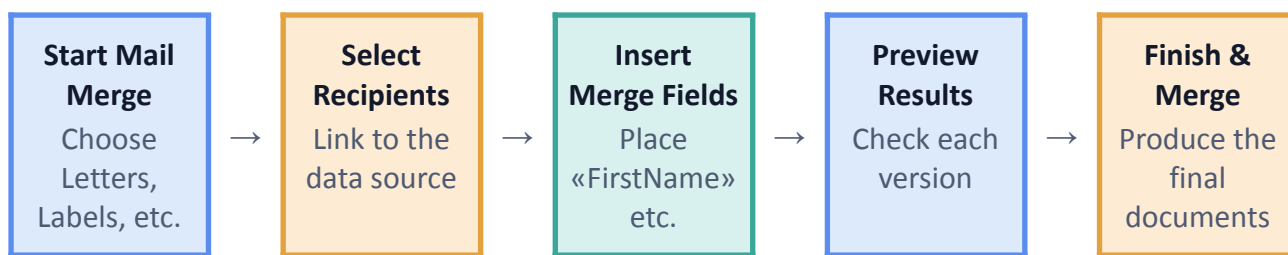


Fig 3.1 — The five-step mail merge process, on the Mailings tab.

- 1. Start Mail Merge:** Mailings tab → Start Mail Merge → choose the type of document to produce (Letters, E-mail Messages, Envelopes, Labels, or a Directory).
- 2. Select Recipients:** Mailings tab → Select Recipients → use an existing list (such as an Excel file), type a new list directly, or choose from Outlook Contacts.
- 3. Insert Merge Fields:** place the cursor exactly where a personalised detail should appear, then Mailings tab → Insert Merge Field → choose the field, such as «FirstName» or «AmountDue».
- 4. Preview Results:** Mailings tab → Preview Results → step through each recipient's personalised version to check that every field has merged correctly.
- 5. Finish & Merge:** Mailings tab → Finish & Merge → choose Edit Individual Documents (creates one combined file with every letter), Print Documents (sends every letter straight to the printer), or Send E-mail Messages.

Important Point for Exams

Always run Preview Results before Finish & Merge. This is the step that catches errors — such as a missing field or an incorrectly linked data source — before hundreds of personalised documents are created or printed.

4 The Data Source

The data source is usually an Excel spreadsheet, a Word table, an Access database, or an Outlook Contacts list, structured so that each column is a field and each row is one complete recipient record.

FirstName	LastName	AmountDue	DueDate
Diya	Sharma	₹2,500	10 Sep 2026
Aman	Verma	₹1,800	10 Sep 2026

A simple mail merge data source: each column is a field, each row is one recipient's record.

Common data source formats: Excel worksheet, Word table, Microsoft Access database, and Outlook Contacts.

5 Types of Mail Merge Output

Mail Merge Can Produce			
Letters One full personalised page per recipient	Envelopes Recipient address printed directly on	Labels Personalised address labels for mailing	E-mail Messages Sent directly, via Outlook

Fig 3.2 — The main types of document a mail merge can produce.

Directory: a fifth, less common output type, which combines every record into a single continuous document — such as a printed member list or catalogue — rather than producing one separate page per recipient.

6 Automated Letter Writing — A Worked Example

Consider a main document letter containing the following text, with merge fields shown in double angle brackets:

Main Document (Template)

Dear «FirstName» «LastName», this is to inform you that your outstanding balance of «AmountDue» is due by «DueDate». Please make the payment at your earliest convenience.
Sincerely, The Accounts Team.

When this main document is merged with the data source from Section 4, Word automatically produces one complete, personalised letter per row — the first addressed to “Dear Riya Sharma... ₹2,500... 10 Sep 2026,” and the second addressed to “Dear Aman Verma... ₹1,800... 10 Sep 2026” — without the fixed wording ever needing to be retyped.

7 Printing Documents

A document is printed via File → Print (or the shortcut Ctrl+P), which also shows a Print Preview so the layout can be checked before anything is actually printed.

Setting	What It Controls
Copies	How many copies of the document to print.
Print Range	Whether to print all pages, only the current page, or a custom range (e.g. “2-4” for pages 2 to 4).
One-Sided / Two-Sided	Whether to print on one side of the paper only, or both sides (also called duplex printing).
Collated / Uncollated	For multiple copies of a multi-page document: collated keeps each copy's pages in order (1,2,3, 1,2,3); uncollated groups all copies of each page together (1,1, 2,2, 3,3).

Orientation	Portrait (tall) or Landscape (wide) page direction.
Pages Per Sheet	Printing more than one document page onto a single sheet of paper, useful for compact handouts.

8 Exporting to PDF

PDF (Portable Document Format) is a file format that preserves a document's exact fonts, formatting, and layout, regardless of the software, device, or operating system used to open it.

Reason	Explanation
Consistent appearance	A PDF looks identical on any computer or device, since fonts and layout are fixed inside the file itself.
Prevents easy editing	Unlike a Word file, a PDF's content generally cannot be casually changed by the reader.
Universally readable	PDFs can be opened using many free PDF reader programs, without needing MS Word installed.
Professional/official use	Commonly used for the final version of resumes, official letters, forms, and printable documents.
Method	Steps
Export menu	File → Export → Create PDF/XPS Document → Create PDF/XPS.
Save As menu	File → Save As → choose a location → set “Save as type” to PDF.

9 Printing vs Exporting to PDF

Point	Printing	Exporting to PDF
Output	Physical paper	A digital file
Sharing	Must be physically handed over or mailed	Can be emailed or uploaded instantly
Consistency across devices	Fixed once printed	Looks identical on any device with a PDF reader
Editable afterwards	Cannot be changed once printed	The file itself is not easily editable by the reader

Best for	Physical mailing, signing by hand, in-person distribution	Digital sharing, archiving, official records
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10 Full Recap — Feature Location Table

Feature	Ribbon Tab / Menu	Key Action
Mail Merge	Mailings	Mailings → Start Mail Merge
Select Recipients	Mailings	Mailings → Select Recipients
Insert Merge Field	Mailings	Mailings → Insert Merge Field
Preview Results	Mailings	Mailings → Preview Results
Finish & Merge	Mailings	Mailings → Finish & Merge
Print a Document	File	File → Print (Ctrl+P)
Export to PDF	File	File → Export, or File → Save As → PDF

11 Putting It All Together — A Worked Example

Consider a college club preparing personalised invitation letters for an annual event, for 200 members:

Step	Feature Used	What Happens
1	Main Document	A single invitation letter is written, with merge fields for «FirstName» and «SeatNumber».
2	Data Source	An Excel spreadsheet listing all 200 members' names and assigned seat numbers is prepared.
3	Select Recipients & Insert Merge Fields	The spreadsheet is linked to the letter, and the merge fields are placed in the correct spots.
4	Preview Results	A few sample letters are checked to confirm names and seat numbers appear correctly.
5	Finish & Merge	All 200 personalised letters are generated as one combined document.

6	Export to PDF	The combined document is exported to PDF, creating a permanent, consistently formatted digital record of every letter sent.
7	Print	The letters are printed, with two-sided printing enabled to save paper, ready to be handed out or mailed.

This single practical task uses every idea from this lecture: mail merge to personalise 200 letters automatically, PDF export to keep a permanent digital archive, and printing to produce the final physical copies.

12 Fill in the Blanks

- 1. Mail merge combines a _____ document with a _____ to create multiple personalised documents.
- 2. In mail merge, each column in the data source is called a(n) _____.
- 3. In mail merge, each row in the data source represents one _____.
- 4. The tab on the ribbon used to perform a mail merge is called the _____ tab.
- 5. Placeholders such as «FirstName» inserted into the main document are called _____.
- 6. Before completing a mail merge, you should use _____ to check each personalised document for errors.
- 7. To print only pages 2 to 4 of a document, you would type _____ in the print range.
- 8. PDF stands for _____.
- 9. Exporting a document to PDF helps ensure it looks the _____ on any device or computer.
- 10. In MS Word, a document can be exported to PDF using File → Export, or File → _____ and choosing PDF as the file type.

Answers

1. Main, Data Source | 2. Field | 3. Recipient (record) | 4. Mailings | 5. Merge fields | 6. Preview Results | 7. 2-4 | 8. Portable Document Format | 9. Same | 10. Save As

13 True or False

- 1. In mail merge, the data source contains the fixed text that is the same in every letter.
- 2. Each row in a mail merge data source usually represents one recipient.
- 3. Mail merge can only be used to create letters, not labels or envelopes.
- 4. Preview Results lets you check each personalised document before completing the merge.
- 5. A PDF file's formatting can change depending on which device or software is used to open it.
- 6. Printing a document on both sides of the paper is called duplex printing.
- 7. The Mailings tab is used to perform a mail merge in MS Word.
- 8. Exporting a document to PDF prevents it from ever being viewed on a different computer.

Answers with Explanation

1. False. It is the reverse: the main document contains the fixed text; the data source contains the changing, personalised details.

- 2. True.** Each row (record) in the data source typically represents one recipient.
- 3. False.** Mail merge can also produce envelopes, labels, e-mail messages, and directories, not only letters.
- 4. True.** That is exactly the purpose of Preview Results.
- 5. False.** A PDF is specifically designed to preserve its exact formatting, regardless of the device or software used to open it.
- 6. True.** Printing on both sides of the paper is called duplex printing.
- 7. True.** The Mailings tab contains all the mail merge tools.
- 8. False.** A PDF is designed to be viewed consistently on virtually any computer or device with a PDF reader; it does not prevent viewing elsewhere.

14 Short Answer Questions (2–3 Marks)

- What is mail merge? (2 marks)
- Differentiate between the main document and the data source in mail merge. (3 marks)
- What is a merge field? (2 marks)
- Name any three types of documents that can be produced using mail merge. (2 marks)
- Why is it important to use Preview Results before finishing a mail merge? (2 marks)
- What is duplex printing? (2 marks)
- Why might someone export a document to PDF instead of just saving it as a Word file? (3 marks)
- How would you print only a specific range of pages from a document? (2 marks)
- Name two ways to export a Word document to PDF. (2 marks)

15 Long Answer Model Answers (5, 10 & 15 Marks)

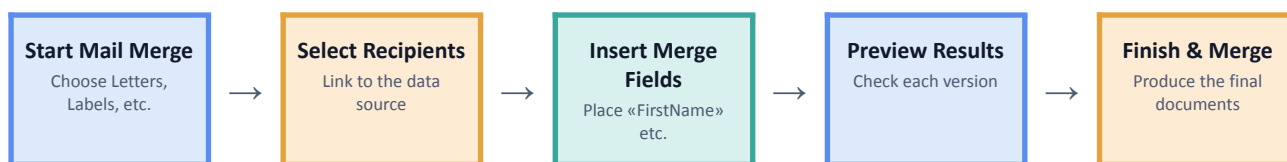
The following are fully written model answers. Use these as a template for structure, depth, and the level of explanation expected in your own exam answer — do not simply memorise them word for word; practise writing them in your own words using the same structure.

Q1 (5 Marks): What is mail merge? Explain its two essential components.

Mail merge is a feature that combines a single template document with a list of data to automatically generate multiple personalised versions of that document, one for each entry in the list, without the user needing to retype or manually edit each copy individually.

Mail merge relies on two essential components. The main document is the template letter itself, containing the fixed text that stays the same for every recipient, along with merge fields — placeholders such as «FirstName» — marking where personalised details should appear. The data source is a list of records, usually an Excel spreadsheet, Word table, or Outlook Contacts list, structured so that each column is a field (such as FirstName or AmountDue) and each row is one complete recipient's record. When merged together, Word produces one finished, personalised document for every row in the data source.

Q2 (10 Marks): Explain, step by step, the process of performing a mail merge to create personalised letters.



(The five-step mail merge process, as in Fig 3.1 of these notes.)

Mail merge is performed entirely from the Mailings tab, in five steps. First, Start Mail Merge is used to choose the type of document being produced, such as Letters. Second, Select Recipients links the letter to a data source, such as an existing Excel spreadsheet. Third, Insert Merge Field is used to place each personalised placeholder, such as «FirstName» or «AmountDue», exactly where that detail should appear in the letter. Fourth, Preview Results steps through each recipient's personalised version, so that any errors — a missing field, or an incorrectly linked column — can be caught before anything is finalised. Finally, Finish & Merge produces the actual output, offering the choice to edit all the individual letters as one combined document, print them directly, or send them as e-mail messages.

In conclusion, following these five steps in order allows dozens or even thousands of fully personalised letters to be produced from a single template and a single data source, in a fraction of the time it would take to write each one by hand.

Q3 (10 Marks): Explain the various options available when printing a document in MS Word, and how to export a document to PDF.

A document is printed via File → Print, or the shortcut Ctrl+P, which opens a Print Preview alongside several key settings.

Setting	What It Controls
Copies	How many copies of the document to print.
Print Range	All pages, only the current page, or a custom range such as “2-4”.
One-Sided / Two-Sided	Whether to print on one side only, or both sides (duplex printing).
Collated / Uncollated	Whether multiple copies keep each copy's pages in order, or group identical pages together.
Orientation	Portrait or Landscape page direction.

A document can be exported to PDF in one of two ways: through File → Export → Create PDF/XPS Document, or through File → Save As, choosing PDF as the “Save as type.” Both methods offer a choice between Standard quality (larger file, suited to printing) and Minimum Size (smaller file, suited to emailing), and an Options button to restrict the page range if only part of the document needs to be exported.

In conclusion, printing and PDF export are the two main ways a finished document leaves MS Word — printing for a physical copy, with fine control over paper use and layout, and PDF export for a consistent, shareable digital copy.

Q4 (15 Marks): Describe, with a suitable example, how an organisation could use mail merge to send personalised letters to a large number of people, and explain how printing and PDF export would each be used to complete the task.

Consider a college club preparing personalised invitation letters for an annual event, for 200 members, each with a different assigned seat number.

Step	What Happens
Main Document	A single invitation letter is written, with merge fields for «FirstName» and «SeatNumber».
Data Source	An Excel spreadsheet listing all 200 members' names and seat numbers is prepared, one row per member.
Select Recipients & Insert Merge Fields	The spreadsheet is linked to the letter, and the merge fields are placed in the correct positions in the text.

Preview Results	A handful of sample letters are checked to confirm every name and seat number has merged correctly.
Finish & Merge	All 200 personalised letters are generated together as a single combined document.

Once merged, **exporting to PDF** creates a permanent, consistently formatted digital record of every one of the 200 letters exactly as sent, which the club can archive or email to members who prefer a digital copy. **Printing** the same combined document, with two-sided (duplex) printing enabled to save paper, produces the physical letters that are actually handed out or posted to members who need a paper copy.

In conclusion, mail merge, PDF export, and printing work together as a complete pipeline: mail merge automates the otherwise impossible task of personalising 200 separate letters, PDF export preserves a permanent, shareable digital record of the finished result, and printing produces the physical copies the task ultimately requires — each step handling a different part of the same real-world job.

16 Exam Tips

- Memory trick for the mail merge steps: “Start, Select, Insert, Preview, Finish” — always in this order.
- Memory trick for mail merge components: Main Document = the WORDS that stay the same; Data Source = the DETAILS that change.
- For “differentiate” questions (main document vs data source, printing vs PDF export), always answer using a table — it is faster to write and easier for the examiner to award marks clearly.
- For “explain how to...” questions, always answer as a numbered, step-by-step sequence, naming the exact ribbon tab and button at each step — exactly like the model answers in Section 15.
- Common Mistake: Do not say mail merge can only produce letters — remember envelopes, labels, e-mail messages, and directories too.
- Common Mistake: Do not say a PDF cannot be shared or viewed elsewhere — the opposite is true; PDF exists specifically to be viewed consistently on any device.
- Always mention the exact menu path or shortcut where one exists (Ctrl+P for printing) — examiners often award a mark specifically for naming it.
- For 10 and 15 mark questions, structure your answer with a clear paragraph or table per component, exactly like the model answers in Section 15 — examiners reward clear structure over long, unstructured paragraphs.

References

- Refer to your university-prescribed/standard Office Productivity Tools textbook for this topic, as per the syllabus official reading list.
- Class lecture discussion and practical demonstration for this lecture.
- MDC Section II, Lecture 2 — MS Word: Tables, Objects, Page Layout & Proofing Tools, for the formatting foundation this lecture builds on.
- Supplementary digital resources on the BSc CS Academic Portal (abhiresearchscholar-cmyk.github.io/bsc-cs-academic-portal), used here for cross-checking terminology and feature names.

MDC Section II, Lecture 3 — Mail Merge, Printing & PDF Export — taking a finished document all the way to its final, real-world destination.